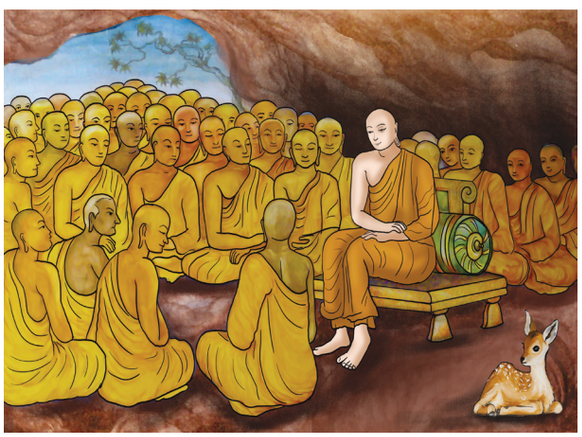
Mahakaccayana and Ananda. Buddha had a huge following among both the royalty and lay persons.

## Buddhist Councils

After the death of Buddha, the tenets and other aspects of Buddhism were decided upon in the councils of Buddhist monks. Over a period of time, four Buddhist councils were held. The First Buddhist Council was held at Rajagriha after Buddha's death, under the patronage of Ajata Satru. It was headed by Upali. In this council, Upali recited the *Vinaya Pitaka.* Ananda recited *Sutta Pitaka.* The Second Buddhist Council met at Vaishali a century after Buddha's death. The Buddhist Order split into two later. One was called the *Sthaviravadins* or 'Believers in the Teachings of the Elders' and the other known as *Mahasanghikas* or 'Members of the Great Community'. The Third Buddhist Council was held at Pataliputra. It was convened by Asoka. The *Sthaviravadins* established themselves strongly and expelled the heretics. The last section called "Kathavatthu" was added to *Abhidhamma Pitaka.* The Fourth Buddhist Council was held at Kashmir during the reign of Kanishka. *Sarvastivadins* were an important sect of Buddhism. Its doctrines were compiled in *Mahavibhasa.*



**Buddhist Council**

## Buddhist Sects

In course of time, *Mahasanghikas, Sthaviravadins* and *Sarvastivadins* emerged as major sects of Buddhism. New ideas emerged among the *Mahasanghikas* and *Sarvastivadins.* It led to the emergence of *Mahayana* and *Hinayana* (the Great and Lesser Vehicles) in Buddhism. *Mahayana* or the Great Vehicle became popular and influential in India. Nalanda University was an important centre of Buddhist learning and was patronised by the Palas. *Mahayana* spread to China and Japan. *Hinayana* or the Lesser Vehicle became popular in Sri Lanka, Burma, Thailand and other South-east Asian countries. By the end of the Gupta period, *Vajrayana* or the Vehicle of the Thunderbolt emerged. It was popular in Bengal and Bihar. It was influenced by primitive local cults and spread to Tibet in the 11th century CE. The Vikramasila University in Bihar was an important centre of *Vajrayana* Buddhism. Buddhism in India began to decline with the onset of the Bhakti movement. Slowly Buddhism came to be influenced by Hindu practices. Soon, Buddhism was incorporated into Hinduism, and Buddha came to be considered as an avatar of Vishnu in some traditions.

## Buddhist Literature

The Buddhist texts were compiled in Pali. The Pali canons are called as the Tripitakas (Three Baskets). They are *Vinaya Pitaka*, *Sutta Pitaka and Abhidhamma Pitaka.Vinaya Pitaka* deals with monastic rules and moral disciplines. *Sutta Pitaka* dwells upon discourses and teachings of Buddha. *Abhidhamma Pitaka* expounds Buddhist philosophy. The *Sutta Pitaka*, which contains the teachings of Buddha, is divided into five groups or *Nikayas.*

### The Starving Tigress: A Jataka Tale

Born in a family renowned for purity of conduct and great spiritual devotion, the Bodhisattva became a great scholar and teacher. With no desire for wealth, he went to a forest and led a life of an ascetic. It was in this forest he encountered a starving tigress, which after giving birth to cubs was about to eat her own new born cubs for survival. With no food in sight, the Bodhisattva offered his body as food to the tigress out of compassion.



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